SAMPLE SUPERSTORE · US RETAIL · JAN 2015 TO DEC 2018

Sales Performance: Business Insights Report

Analysis of 9,993 order lines from 5,009 orders placed by 793 customers across 49 US states. Covers revenue trends, product performance, customer behaviour and regional results, with recommendations.

Revenue	Profit	Margin	Orders	Customers	Avg order	Return rate
$2.30M	**$286K**	**12.5%**	**5,009**	**793**	**$459**	**5.9%**

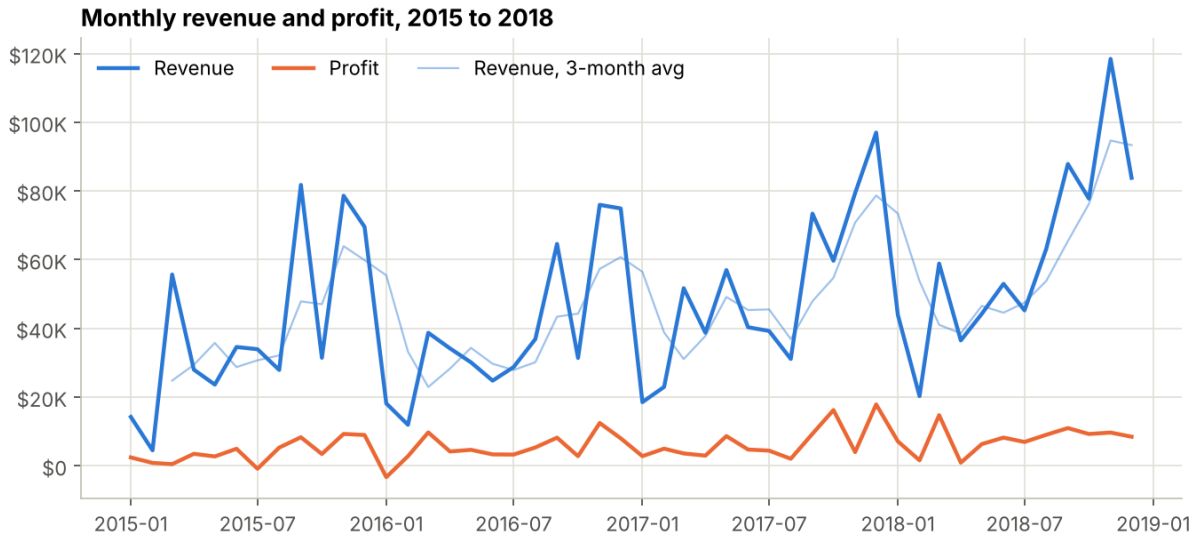
Executive summary

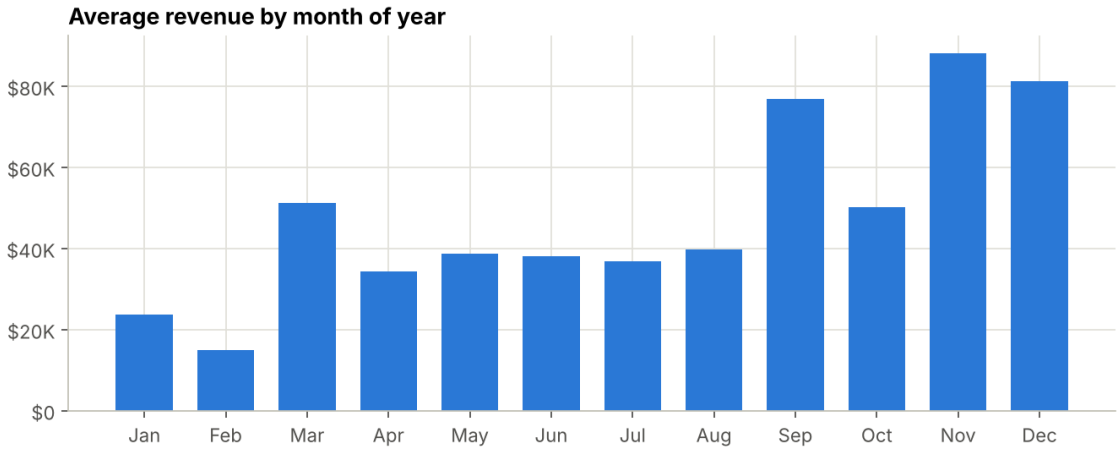
- **Growth is strong.** Revenue rose from $483,966 in 2015 to $733,215 in 2018, a 14.9% compound annual growth rate. Profit grew faster, from $49,556 to $93,439.
- **Discounting is the biggest profit leak.** Lines discounted more than 20% brought in $362,489 of revenue and lost $135,364. Undiscounted lines earn a 29.5% margin.
- **Furniture is a volume trap.** It is 32.3% of revenue but only 6.4% of profit. Tables and Bookcases lose money outright.
- **Central underperforms.** Central's margin is 7.9% against 14.9% in the West. Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois together lose $71K.
- **Customers are loyal and concentrated.** 98% ordered more than once, and the top 20% of customers produce 48% of revenue.
- **Demand is seasonal.** September to December bring 52% of annual revenue.

1. Revenue trends

Revenue dipped 2.8% in 2016, then grew 29.5% in 2017 and 20.4% in 2018. Margin improved from 10.2% in 2015 to about 13% in each later year. Orders rose every year, from 969 to 1,687, while the average order value fell from $499 to $435, so growth came from more orders rather than larger ones.

Year	Revenue	Growth	Profit	Margin	Orders	Customers
2015	$483,966	–	$49,556	10.2%	969	595
2016	$470,533	-2.8%	$61,619	13.1%	1,038	573
2017	$609,206	+29.5%	$81,795	13.4%	1,315	638
2018	$733,215	+20.4%	$93,439	12.7%	1,687	693

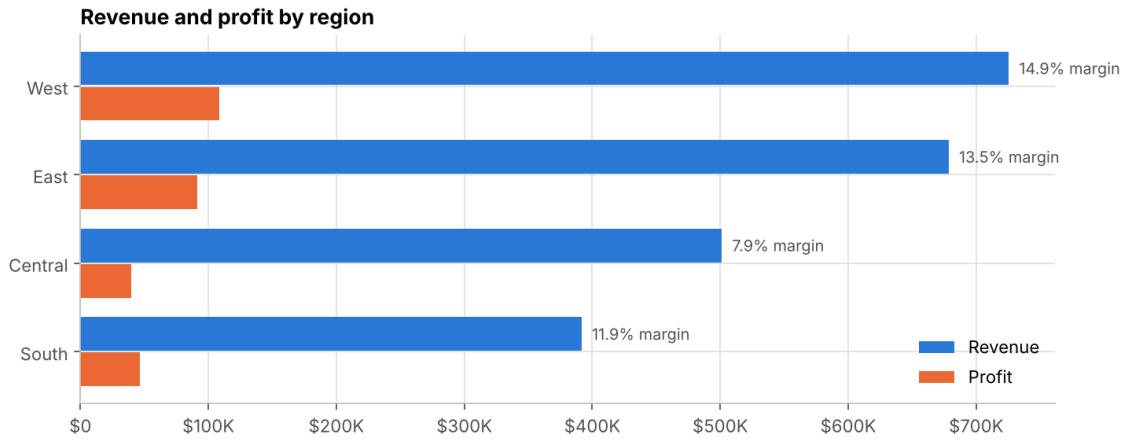

Monthly revenue and profit, 2015 to 2018
Revenue
Profit
Revenue, 3-month avg
$120K
$100K
$80K
$60K
$40K
$20K
$0
2015-01
2015-07
2016-01
2016-07
2017-01
2017-07
2018-01
2018-07
2019-01

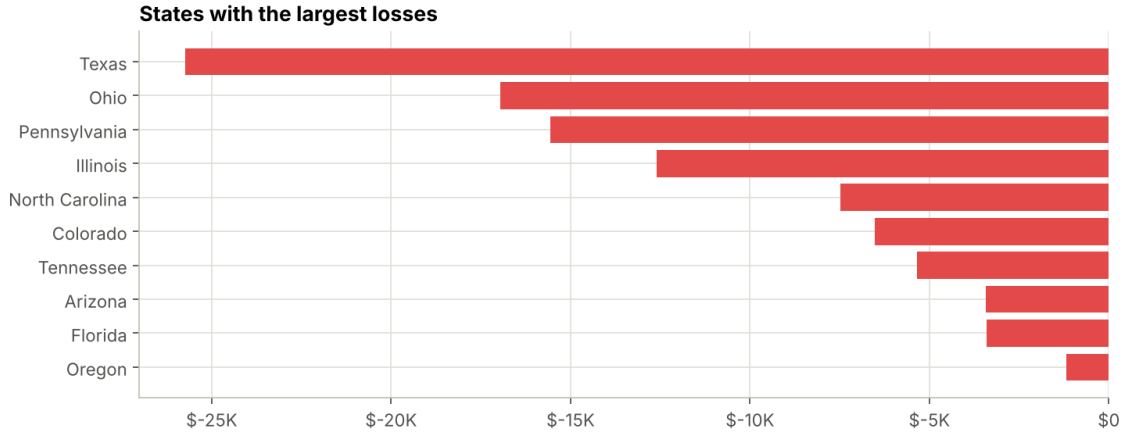

Average revenue by month of year
$80K
$60K
$40K
$20K
$0
Jan
Feb
Mar
Apr
May
Jun
Jul
Aug
Sep
Oct
Nov
Dec

2. Regional performance

The West and East generate 61% of revenue and 70% of profit. Central sells more than the South but earns less profit, because Central's Furniture loses money and its Binders and Appliances are sold at deep discounts. Texas is the third-largest state by revenue yet the largest loss-maker.

Region	Revenue	Share	Profit	Margin	Orders
West	$725,458	31.6%	$108,418	14.9%	1,611
East	$678,500	29.5%	$91,535	13.5%	1,401
Central	$501,240	21.8%	$39,706	7.9%	1,175
South	$391,722	17.1%	$46,749	11.9%	822

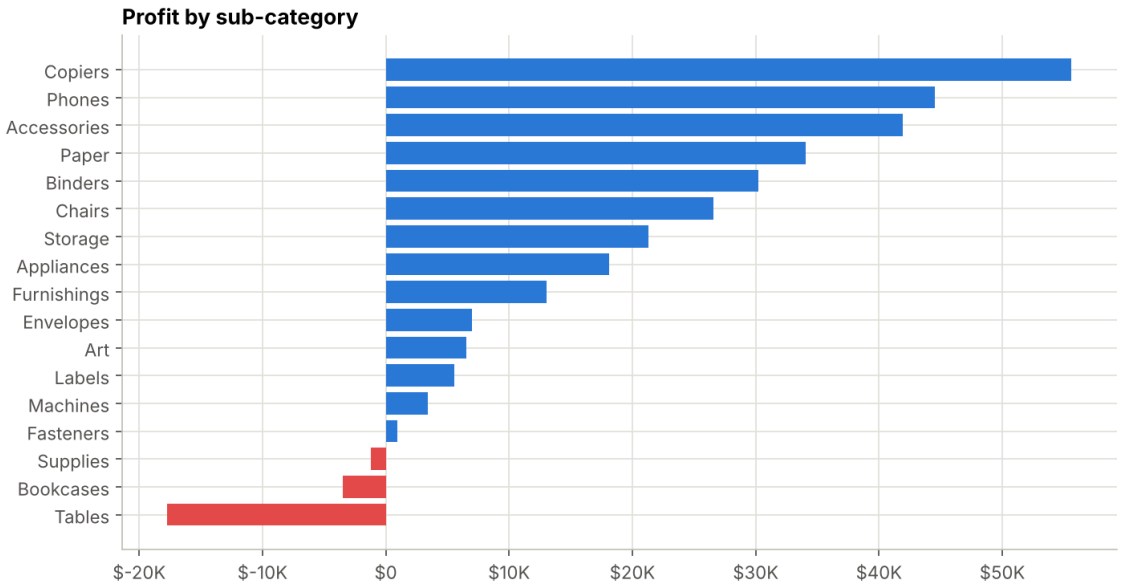




3. Product performance

Technology is the largest and most profitable category. Office Supplies earns a similar margin on lower revenue. Furniture's 2.5% margin is the weak point. At sub-category level, Copiers, Phones and Accessories lead on profit; Tables, Bookcases and Supplies lose money. Revenue is concentrated: the top 20% of the 1,850 products generate 77% of revenue.

Category	Revenue	Share	Profit	Profit share	Margin
Technology	$836,154	36.4%	$145,455	50.8%	17.4%
Furniture	$741,718	32.3%	$18,463	6.4%	2.5%
Office Supplies	$719,047	31.3%	$122,491	42.8%	17.0%



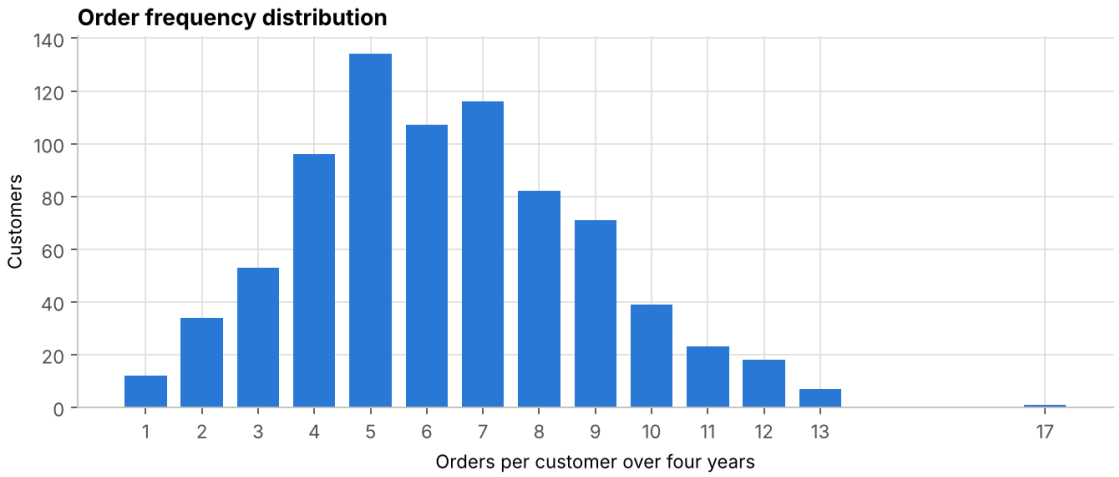
Most profitable products	Revenue	Profit
Canon imageCLASS 2200 Advanced Copier	$61,600	$25,200
Fellowes PB500 Electric Punch Plastic Comb Binding Machine w…	$27,453	$7,753
Hewlett Packard LaserJet 3310 Copier	$18,840	$6,984
Canon PC1060 Personal Laser Copier	$11,620	$4,571
HP Designjet T520 Inkjet Large Format Printer - 24" Color	$18,375	$4,095

Biggest loss-making products	Revenue	Profit
Cubify CubeX 3D Printer Double Head Print	$11,100	-$8,880
Lexmark MX611dhe Monochrome Laser Printer	$16,830	-$4,590
Cubify CubeX 3D Printer Triple Head Print	$8,000	-$3,840
Chromcraft Bull-Nose Wood Oval Conference Tables & Bases	$9,918	-$2,876
Bush Advantage Collection Racetrack Conference Table	$9,545	-$1,934

4. Customer purchasing behaviour

The 793 customers placed a median of 6 orders each over four years. Consumers are half of revenue; Home Office customers are fewest but most profitable per dollar. An RFM (recency, frequency, monetary) segmentation in the notebook finds 176 Champions producing 35% of revenue, and 34 high-value customers who have not ordered in over a year.

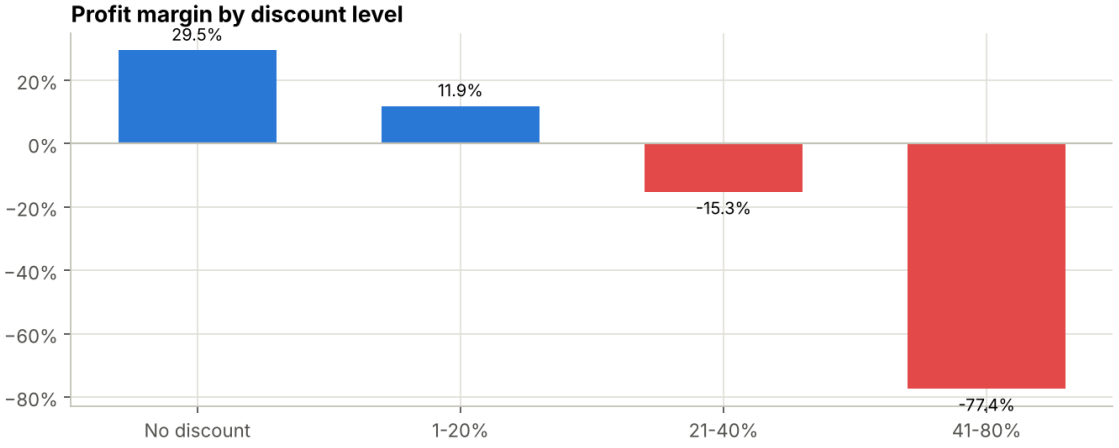
Segment	Revenue	Profit	Margin	Customers	Avg order
Consumer	$1,161,401	$134,119	11.5%	409	$449
Corporate	$706,146	$91,979	13.0%	236	$466
Home Office	$429,372	$60,311	14.0%	148	$472



5. Discounts and profitability

Discount level is the strongest single driver of profit in the data (correlation with line margin -0.86). Up to 20% off, lines stay profitable. Beyond that every band loses money, and at 41 to 80% off the business loses 77 cents for each dollar sold.

Discount	Order lines	Revenue	Profit	Margin
No discount	4,798	$1,087,908	$320,988	29.5%
1-20%	3,803	$846,522	$100,785	11.9%
21-40%	459	$233,857	-$35,805	-15.3%
41-80%	933	$128,632	-$99,559	-77.4%



6. Recommendations

1. **Cap discounts at 20%.** Require manager approval above it. Start with Binders, Machines, Tables and Appliances in Central and the East, where deep discounts lose the most. Bringing the deep-discount lines to break-even alone would add about $135,364 of profit over four years.
2. **Fix or prune Furniture.** Reprice Tables and Bookcases, bundle them with profitable accessories, or drop SKUs that lose money on every sale (for example the Cubify CubeX 3D printers and several conference tables).
3. **Grow the profit engines.** Feature Copiers, Phones, Accessories, Paper and Labels in cross-sell and seasonal campaigns. They carry margins from 13% to 44%.
4. **Turn around Central and the loss states.** Review pricing and promotion policy in Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois, and give Central's regional manager margin targets, not only revenue targets.
5. **Protect the best customers.** Launch a loyalty tier for the top 20% of customers and a win-back offer for the 34 high-value customers who have lapsed.
6. **Plan for the autumn peak.** Align inventory, staffing and marketing spend with September to December, which deliver over half of annual revenue.

Method and data

Source: Tableau's public *Sample - Superstore* dataset (9,994 order lines, 21 columns). The raw CSV also contained the regional-manager and returns tables; these were split out. Cleaning removed one duplicate line, filled 11 missing postal codes (all Burlington, VT), parsed dates and added time, margin, discount-band and returned-order features. Analysis was done in Python (pandas) in *notebooks/sales_analysis.ipynb*; the interactive dashboard is in *dashboard/index.html*. Profit is as recorded in the dataset; returns are flagged but not netted out of revenue.